

The best, is undoubtedly its electronic programme guide (EPG). Add a TV tuner to your PC, and Media Center will convert it into an all-singing, all-dancing personal video recorder (PVR) that can watch, record and time-slip TV programmes. You can also buy a remote control and receiver to operate it from a distance — ideal if you can connect the computer to a high-definition TV. What's more, if you have an Xbox 360 games console, it can be used as a Media Center Extender. If you have a home network, this can give access to all your music, video and TV in another room.

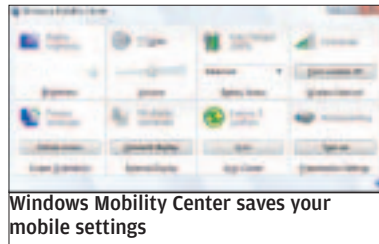
Business class

Although most computers you'll find for sale include Vista Home Premium, it's not uncommon to find notebooks that use Vista Business instead. As the name makes abundantly clear, this version is mainly intended for corporate use, but it also includes a couple of hidden extras that can be useful at home, too.

Windows Shadow Copy sounds bizarre, but it's a really handy feature that runs in the background, saving each previous version of a file — so if, for example, you accidentally crop somebody's head out of a photo then save it, Shadow Copy will have kept the original safe for you. The Vista Business backup tool has a clever trick up its sleeve, too: it can create disk image files. With disk imaging programs available for approximately Rs. 2878, this can be a real money saver, as well as a great way to back up all your files.

Another great hidden feature of Vista Business is the Encrypting File System (EFS). This allows you to quickly and easily scramble the contents of a file or folder so that it can't be read by other users or anyone who might have stolen your computer.

Despite being businesslike, this version still includes the Aero desktop with all its graphical eye-candy. On the other hand, a few features found in Home Premium are missing. You can't make video DVD discs, for instance, and there is no Windows Media Center. A boxed copy of Vista Business costs around approximately Rs. 8,632.



Windows Mobility Center saves your mobile settings



Aero is the technology that gives windows a semi-transparent look and enables the snazzy Flip 3D browser

Superlative stuff

Interestingly, Vista Ultimate — the biggest and most complete version of Vista — can be found online for around approximately Rs. 13,667, making it cheaper than the lesser Business version. Ultimate is notable for including just about every feature from all the other versions of Vista, with home entertainment tools such as Media Center and DVD burning and the office tools from Vista Business built-in. This makes it ideal for the indecisive or completists, but does it have any hidden extras all to itself, and are they any good?

The answer is yes and no. Vista Ultimate includes access to a collection of 'Ultimate Extras' but so far these have been rather underwhelming: you can download new sounds, video wallpaper, and a poker game for example, but nothing truly groundbreaking.

On the other hand, Vista Ultimate has a hidden trick in the form of Bitlocker. Although Vista Business can use its EFS system to quickly encrypt files and folders, Bitlocker enables Ultimate users to encrypt their entire hard disk should they wish. A USB memory key can be used in place of a password, and the computer will not start Windows without that memory key plugged in.



Business includes Shadow Copy